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Demonstrating a Web-Design Technique in a Distance-Learning Environment

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Objective: To lead a brief training session over a distance-learning network

Type of speech: Informative

Point value: 20% of course grade

Requirements: (a) References: Not specified; (b) Length: 15 minutes; (c) Visual aid: Yes; (d) Outline: No; (e) Prerequisite reading: Chapters 12–16, 18 (Bailey, 2002); (f) Additional requirements: None

This assignment recognizes the growing importance of computer-mediated communication in professional contexts and is designed to introduce undergraduate students to the fundamentals and challenges of giving a speech (as part of a training session on web design) over a distance-learning network via live interactive video. Teleconferencing is becoming a popular means of doing business for companies whose employees, clients, and contractors may be geographically scattered. Moreover, a number of companies now offer some employees the option of working from their homes at least a few days a week. Videoconferencing from home (in the form of an inexpensive web cam, speakers, and microphone connected to an Internet-ready computer) allows telecommuters to exchange information with colleagues conveniently and affordably. Finally, distance-learning courses, especially at multi-campus universities, are becoming more popular not only as a way to manage exploding student populations, but also to serve the needs of students pursuing degrees at multiple campuses.

Directions

1. Select an approved topic (or propose one) that requires you to demonstrate to your audience how to do something on the computer. The topic should be one in which you teach your audience a web-design skill (e.g., organizing, naming, titling, and saving web files; making a simple web page and saving it; providing

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an overview of link types and creating links using FrontPage, Dreamweaver, or Composer; creating a graphic headline in Photoshop; making a left-edge graphic as a web page background; creating a HTML table and demonstrating the value of tables). Read Williams and Tollett (2000) to generate topic ideas and find instructions for a number of possible topics.

2. Design a 10–12 minute PowerPoint presentation that incorporates the techniques discussed in Bailey (2002) and demonstrates your mastery of screen capture software (for capturing images of windows and/or menus to use in your presentation).
3. Give your PowerPoint presentation to both sections of the class simultaneously. Emphasize the proper use of eye contact and gaze at *both* locations and ensure the audiences at both sites are on task. For example, you will need to divide your time between the local and the remote audience by giving “gaze time” to the “teacher cam” that projects your image to the remote site.
4. Manage the options on the lectern interface so that participants at the remote location can see you while you give your PowerPoint presentation (i.e., choose one of the following options on the distance-learning interface: “Picture-in-Picture,” “Desktop,” or “Teacher Cam”).
5. Encourage audience members to follow along at their individual computer stations as you demonstrate your computer technique. You may need to adjust the speed of your presentation depending upon how quickly your audience members are able to follow your directions on their computers. Because you will be giving a realistic training session on some aspect of web design, you should expect and encourage your audience to ask questions *during* your presentation. Do not let questions, however, prevent you from finishing your presentation. Aim for a balance between making sure that audience members are keeping up *and* finishing your demonstration on time.
6. Supply your audience members with additional materials or files, where appropriate. For example, if your topic involves manipulating images in a graphics program such as Photoshop, you will probably need to supply the audience with a sample image with which they can work during your demonstration. Electronic files will need to be saved on the department’s server or in another location before class so participants can access it from their individual workstations during your presentation and demonstration.
7. Following your presentation, be prepared for questions that may require you to display an audience member’s computer screen on the projection screens at both locations simultaneously. To do this, you will need to be familiar with the *network monitoring software* at the lectern machine that allows a presenter to view and/or control one or more of the lab computers at the local and remote sites.

Debriefing

1. What are the benefits and drawbacks of giving a presentation in a distance-learning environment?

2. What is the most challenging aspect of giving a presentation in a distance-learning environment?
3. How would you redesign the distance-learning classrooms and the individual computer stations in these classrooms to facilitate the exchange of information across a computer network?

Appraisal

This assignment grounds public speaking in a context of learning and teaching others about technology. It assumes that computer-mediated communication, from text-based chat to two-way interactive audio- and video-linking meeting spaces such as computer labs, is becoming an increasingly popular, and in some cases relatively inexpensive, way to reduce distance and facilitate collaboration among professionals. Although some students will struggle to achieve expertise with the distance-learning network and with web-design principles and techniques, nearly all students emerge from the experience with an appreciation of the ways in which technology enables and constrains communication.

References and Suggested Readings

- Bailey, E. P. (2002). *Writing & speaking at work: A practical guide for business communications* (2nd ed.). Upper Saddle River, NJ: Prentice-Hall.
- Williams, R., & Tollett, J. (2000). *The non-designer's web book* (2nd ed). Berkeley, CA: Peachpit Press.